

PULLING EXERCISES

L-Sit / Straddle-L / V-Sits / Manna – Page 1, Column 9

There are four different phases to training the V-sit and Manna, with different concepts to focus on in each phase. In order to avoid vague coaching advice like *just go higher*, these skills are grouped into phases for each step in the progression.

If you are following the charts you will see that varying angles are marked somewhat subjectively. Knowing your angles will give you a decent measure of where you are on the A-C range in your development. This is helpful since the V-sit is an A-Level skill and the manna is a C-Level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points. The difficulty on the progression charts is true to their respective gymnastics origins while simultaneously presenting indicators for progress between each phase. This applies to all of the exercises listed, not just this specific progression.

You will notice on the charts that there is a lot of variation in the angles per level. You'll see a big jump to 100 degrees near the beginning and it slowly decreases from there. This is because as the angle decreases, torque increases exponentially. When your muscles move outside of the optimal range of motion, the force output of your muscles decreases in that range. Every 30-degree increase essentially doubles the level of difficulty for execution. This is especially true with similar skills like the iron cross and planche.

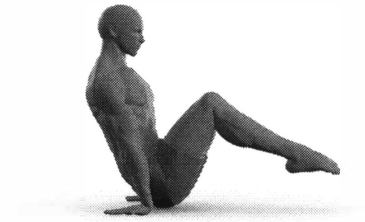
Anyone who wants to begin serious bodyweight strength training should at least *attempt* to learn the V-sit and manna progression. Not only are these skills pleasing to the eye, they are also excellent for working the muscles in your posterior shoulder and scapular areas, which are necessary to shoulder health.

Because gymnastics-based bodyweight strength training is a very “hands in front of the body” endeavor, it lends itself to building muscular imbalances in the front of your body that often lead to a “caveman” look (shoulders hunched forward, neck craned out). This is called upper-crossed syndrome, which not only looks bad, but also increases your chance of injury. Training this series of progressions will help keep your shoulders healthy and lead toward a longer training career in which you will accomplish great feats (including these).

Note that your hands will be held backward in all of these skills. Most beginners will have to start with their hands sideways. However, try to train some with the hands backward to get used to the position. When you transition from the V-sit progression to the manna progression, hands held backwards will be a requirement, which is why practicing it at the lower levels of L-sit training is recommended. Until that time, your hands should face sideways as opposed to forward because you will probably want to perform this skill on rings or parallel bars at some point.

Phase I

TUCK L-SIT – LEVEL 1



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully depressed and neutral. There is a tendency in some of these positions to allow your shoulders to drift forward so that your chest rounds, or to force scapular retraction. Avoid this.

Technique: Place your hands backward. While on your toes or butt, lean back so that your weight shifts to your hands and slowly lift off the ground.

The *tuck L-sit* is a very simple hold. Execute it on the floor to ensure proper shoulder activation. If you are unable to perform this hold on the floor, you can use an elevated surface like parallel bars, parallettes, a few chairs, or a set of mats.

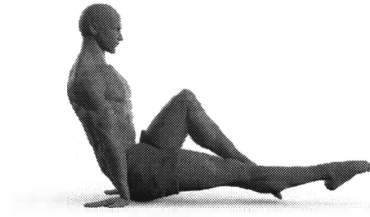
1. Make sure your arms remain locked straight.
2. Depress your scapulae as far as possible (so your shoulders do not rise up toward your ears).
3. Your thighs should be at a 45-degree angle with your torso, and your legs should be at a 90-degree angle with your thighs.

Your legs may be extended to make the exercise more challenging; however, if you find you are progressing very quickly you may have the strength to move to the next level immediately.

If you do not yet have the ability to raise the legs this high, a variation of this skill uses raised implements to do a “chair” L-sit hold. In this variation, the thighs are held at 90 degrees to the torso and the legs are held at 90 degrees to the thighs—exactly like a seated chair position except your hands provide the only support.

This is an A-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

ONE-LEG-BENT L-SIT – LEVEL 2



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully depressed and neutral. There is a tendency in some of these positions to allow your shoulders to drift forward so that your chest rounds, or to force scapular retraction. Avoid this.

Technique: Place your hands backward. While in a seated position with one leg bent, lean back and place your weight on your hands. Next, lift your legs off the ground completely.

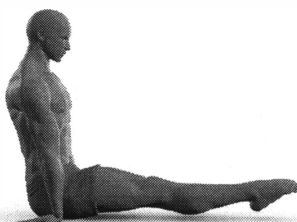
This progression is the transition sequence between the *tuck L-sit* and *full L-sit*. If you have never performed a full L-sit you may feel some cramping in your abdominals, hip flexors, or the quadriceps muscle groups in your extended leg. Additionally, if your hamstrings lack the proper flexibility for this skill, they may feel tight and pull on the back of your leg. If this is the case, implement some hamstring mobility drills into your warm-up, workout, or post-workout routine.

Muscle cramping is uncomfortable, but a fairly normal bodily response. Cramping is addressed in Chapter 21, which talks about common bodyweight training injuries. For the most part, cramping only occurs in fatigued, oxygen-deprived muscles. This often occurs near the end of a workout, when you are tired.

If you experience cramping in your muscles, massage it out and then continue to work the affected area. Do not be afraid of this type of pain, as it dissipates quickly with higher training frequency and consistency. Working out twice, preferably three times per week, will rid this nuisance quickly. Additionally, try to practice your L-sit and other associated skill work while you still feel fresh.

This is an A-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

L-SIT – LEVEL 3



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully depressed and neutral. There is a tendency in some of these positions to allow your shoulders to drift forward so that your chest rounds, or to force scapular retraction. Avoid this.

Technique: Place your hands backward. While in a seated position with both legs straight, lean back and place your weight on your hands. Next, lift your legs off the ground completely.

The *L-sit* is executed by supporting your body only with straight arms and raising your legs to a parallel position with the ground. You should keep your shoulder girdle depressed to prevent your shoulders from rising up close to your ears. Depressing your shoulders keeps them “active” and in a good position for other techniques that transition out of the L-sit, such as straight-arm press to handstands. If you are seeking to transition to this skill from the previous progression, focus primarily on getting your legs out straight while still being able to hold them at a 90-degree angle. There are two ways to do this.



Compression work. Instead of trying to lift your toes up, which will often tilt your torso back, focus on lifting your knees to your chest without bending your legs. To do this, squeeze your quadriceps muscle group tightly and use your hip flexors and abdominals to pull as hard as possible. You can also improve through specific compression work (covered in programming with specific core work, in Chapter 9). Focus on contracting your quadriceps, hip flexors, and abdominals, much like the previous exercise. However, instead of supporting your body with your arms, you will place your legs on the ground with your hands next to them. Apply pressure through your hands while lifting only your legs (think knees toward your face) to isolate the specific muscles in question. This allows a stronger contraction and thus more efficient compression. Compression work is critical to good bodyweight strength development. The challenge level can be raised by moving your arms out, closer to your feet, while keeping them in contact with the floor in order to push through them.

Depending on your goals, split volume 50/50 between L-sit holds and compression work. You have to practice both the skill and compression to excel in the long run. As you improve and your knees get closer to your chest and head, you will begin to do more compression and hamstring flexibility work. When you are already proficient with body positions and the static holds you want to achieve, you will need more specific compression work to progress with the skills that require extreme compression like the press handstands and manna.

This is an A-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

STRADDLE L-SIT – LEVEL 4



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully depressed and slightly protracted. Unlike the L-sit, you begin the *straddle L-sit* leaned over slightly, which means you will have to protract your scapulas.

Technique: Place your hands between your legs while sitting in a straddle position with your legs on the floor. Push down on the floor to lift your body up, and simultaneously contract your abdominals and hip flexors to lift your legs off the floor.

While the *straddle L-sit* is visually similar to the *L-sit*, it is actually a completely different exercise. If you want to become good at both of these skills, you will need to practice each of them extensively. It is often the case that the straddle L-sit needs to be practiced significantly more than the L-sit.

To execute the straddle L-sit, begin by straddling your legs at least 90 degrees while seated on the ground. Next, place your hands inside of your legs, approximately shoulder-width apart. This will put you in a more disadvantaged position than the L-sit, as your hips will likely impair you from shifting your weight forward onto your hands. To compensate for this and execute the skill, depress your shoulders and lean forward to shift more pressure onto your hands. This is a bit more difficult than it would be with your arms outside of your legs, but persevere.

After your weight has shifted forward, lift your legs off the ground. This is difficult because your legs are an oblique angle to your torso. Your abdominals will not have a good line of pull on your pelvis. Focus on rotating your groin up, toward your stomach. Note that your hip flexors will also be in a disadvantaged position due to their line of pull. This makes everything much harder and makes cramping much more likely, especially in your quadriceps and hip flexors. When cramping occurs, stop, shake, and rub out the cramps. Then continue with your training. With continual practice, cramping will eventually cease. If you are experiencing great difficulty, you can work one leg at a time or do compression work. If you need more strategies to treat cramping, see Chapter 21.

There is a variation of this skill which is easier. This is with one hand on the inside of both legs and one hand on the outside of one leg. If you are having trouble holding yourself off the ground, you can start with one hand inside and one hand outside approach to get used to the position. Then work toward both hands between the legs as you improve.

This is an A-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

RINGS-TURNED-OUT L-SIT – LEVEL 5

Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully depressed and neutral. There is a tendency in some of these positions to allow your shoulders to drift forward so that your chest rounds, or to force scapular retraction. Avoid this.

Technique: Lift yourself up on the rings with your arms straight. Next, bring your legs up into an L-sit position. (For the *straddle L-sit*, bring your hips behind your hands and bring your legs up into a straddle position with your hands placed between your legs and pushing down.) Work on turning the rings from the turned-in position where your forearms are on the straps, to the parallel position, to the turned-out position where your palms are pointing forward. Maintain your legs at parallel or higher.

Going from a stable surface to the rings increases difficulty due to the lack of stability. For both the L-sit and straddle L-sit, the technique is the same on the rings as on the floor, except you must squeeze the rings as tight to your body as possible. Aside from that, the skill is exactly the same.

Keep your shoulder girdle depressed and squeeze your abdominals, hip flexors, and quadriceps. Remember to squeeze every muscle in your body as hard as possible—the extra tension will help stabilize the rings.

Along with simply practicing on the floor, holding yourself in ring support a few times per week is usually all that is needed to obtain this skill. If you cramp, shake it out, massage your muscles, and try again. If you need more strategies to treat cramping, see Chapter 21.

These are an A-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

Phase II

TRAINING TOWARD THE V-SIT AND MANNA

As a beginner, working toward the V-sit is a waste of time because your hands will typically be pointed forward or to the side. Instead, focus on the manna, as it will give you the corresponding V-sit angle(s) that you desire. This is why you have been practicing hands-backward positioning. These angles are approximate, but the reference points are solid:

- 45-degree V-Sit – Level 6
- 75-degree V-Sit – Level 7
- Rings-Turned-Out Straddle-L – Level 6
- Rings 45-degree V-Sit – Level 7
- Rings 75-degree V-Sit – Level 8
- Rings 90-degree V-Sit – Level 9

Quick Note: Rings V-sits are not included on the charts, however they are rated in this phase because of the inherent instability of the rings. The optional rings-turned-out positions will help you get your hips up, although they are unstable.



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully depressed and neutral. There is a tendency in some of these positions to allow your shoulders to drift forward so that your chest rounds, or to force scapular retraction. Avoid this.

Technique: You will begin in a straddle position, with your hands on the floor behind you. Your hands should be positioned at the back of your hips, with your fingers facing away from your body. First, load as much weight as possible onto your hands. Second, depress your shoulder girdle as much as possible by pushing your shoulders away from your ears. Third, tense your abdominals and curl your pelvis as if you are trying to touch your shoulders with your toes. (You want your hips/groin to point upward as much as possible.) Now lean back on your arms while pushing your hands backwards into the ground. Spread your legs as far apart as possible and lift them off the ground to the furthest angle you are able. You should eventually be able to move them close to vertical. Consistently depress your shoulder girdle and keep rounding your back and pelvis.

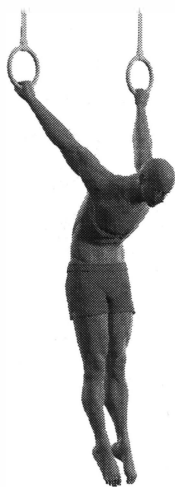
Get proficient with this position; it will be vital all the way up to the manna itself.

At first it appears as if these angles can be achieved simply through specific abdominal compression work. While this is true, it misses the key point of working toward the manna. The backward-hands technique plays a significant role in skill development. Once this position has been established and reinforced, the progression of the manna is about pushing your hips forward. There are two mental cues you can use to achieve this:

- Simply focus on pushing your hips forward in order to create space between your forearms and hips. This will allow you to get higher into the position. You do not want to focus on pushing your hips upward, as this tends to cause you to lean back on your hands, which will not actually lift your hips off the hands.
- Shove your palms and fingers into the floor, directly backward, as hard as possible, in order to propel the rest of your body forward. Simultaneously resist this by compressing your body as tightly as possible. This will also keep you from uselessly leaning back.

Depending on your compression abilities, you might be able to lift your legs up into the V-sit to 45 or 75 degrees right away. Do not practice this now. Instead, focus on progressing into the next phase. Couple compression work with the hips-forward training shown above. Think of this phase in terms of two important concepts: You want to focus on this hold to reinforce your hip push, and you want to improve your core compression. Each of these factors is crucial, not only for the development of the V-sit and manna, but for core strength and control.

Supplementary work will help tremendously since this is such an inherently difficult progression. Here are two recommended supplements to use while training for the manna:



German Hang / Skin the Cat – This is an excellent shoulder stretching exercise that puts your shoulder into extreme hyperextension. The manna requires excellent shoulder mobility in that range. *German hangs* work well, especially right before any manna training attempts, because stretching out your opposing muscles (pectorals, latissimus dorsi, and anterior deltoids) statically for a period of thirty seconds or more helps inhibit force generation in those muscles. It is possible to get a ten to fifteen degree greater angle of improvement in the next manna attempt after a German hang.



Hamstrings Stretching – The manna involves pushing up into a compressed straddle position, and stretching in the straddle position is preferable. Therefore, any hamstring stretching will help. Once you advance to the next phase of manna training by pushing your hips significantly forward, the inhibition (looseness) in your hamstrings will allow a deeper compression by allowing your quadriceps, hip flexors, and abdominals to pull your knees closer to your face with less resistance. This allows you to achieve a higher angle and improves the balance of the skill. Compression moves your center of mass closer to your hands, which allows the torque generated on your arms and shoulders to lessen.

Phase III

100-degree V-Sit – Level 8

120-degree V-Sit – Level 9

140-degree V-Sit – Level 10

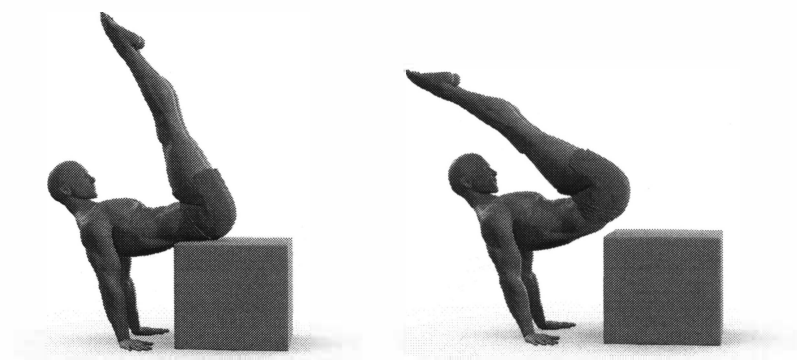


Scapular Positioning: As your legs begin to move past a vertical position and your hips rotate in front of your body, your scapulas will elevate your rib cage. They may also retract slightly because your hands are close together and your shoulder flexibility is being pushed to the limit. This is normal.

Technique: Begin in a straddle position, with your hands on the floor behind you. Your hands should be positioned at the back of your hips, with your fingers facing away from your body. First, load as much weight as possible onto your hands. Second, depress your shoulder girdle as much as possible by pushing your shoulders away from your ears. Third, tense your abdominals and curl your pelvis as if you are trying to touch your shoulders with your toes. (You want your hips/groin to point upward as much as possible.) Now lean back on your arms while simultaneously pushing your hands backwards, into the ground. Spread your legs as far apart as possible and lift them off the ground to the furthest angle you are able. Once your legs are almost vertical, push your hips forward aggressively. You can think of this in terms of either pushing your hips forward, or pushing your hands behind you as far as you are able.

The third phase is entered when you gain the strength to push your hips up to shoulder height. Use everything in your ability to cue the aggressive forward drive of your hips. In this phase, you should notice that all of the muscles in the back of your shoulders are becoming much stronger. The strength that is built in this phase comes to fruition as your whole posterior shoulder girdle becomes extremely strong. Problems with pain or stiffness from shoulder imbalance should ultimately disappear because of the incredible shoulder mobility and strength gained from this exercise.

At this point, switch to supplementary work to progress further. Here are some examples:



High Holds with or without Eccentrics – Use high holds to acclimate your body to positions that are impossible to achieve just by pressing into them. For instance, if your progress is stalling at the 120-degree V-sit mark you can use a chair, couch, mat, or spotter to prop up your hips and part of your lower back. From there, shove your hands back and lean back slightly in order to attempt to hold the higher position. If you get your hips in the right position you can perform slow eccentric lowers from this higher position down to positions you can already hold. (Note: If using a spotter, allow them to minimally assist you in balancing in that higher position, rather than immediately letting go.)

Speed Pushes – Use speed pushes as a power building exercise through full range of motion. When you push up into the manna progression in a slow and controlled manner, you will reach the limit of your abilities rather quickly. A powerful push can allow you to get higher than you can if you push slowly, but it is hard to control yourself at this speed and higher position, so falling backward onto your butt is a likely scenario. The reason why this actually helps is due to the relationship between power and strength. Building raw strength increases potential for speed, but building power (via the same movement, performed quickly) increases both speed and strength. However, quick movements avoid building static stability and sacrifice total volume because less time is spent holding the position.

A combination of presses, high holds, and speed pushes contribute best to success with achieving the manna. Presses into the top holds and high holds should compose most of your training volume. With most end range of motion skills, the best way to build the skill is through training in that end range of motion. There are three reasons for this:

1. Flexibility is best attained at the end of your range of motion.
2. Isometric contraction strength correlates the best within 30 degrees of the specific angle of the joint(s).
3. Applying force in decreased leverage positions at the end of your range of motion builds great strength.

Phase IV

155-degree V-Sit – Level 11

170-degree V-Sit – Level 12

Manna – Level 13



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully depressed and neutral. There is a tendency in some of these positions to allow your shoulders to drift forward so that your chest rounds, or to force scapular retraction. Avoid these.

Technique: Perform the earlier technique. Begin in a straddle position with your hands on the floor behind you. Your hands should be positioned at the back of your hips, with your fingers facing away from your body. First, load as much weight as possible onto your hands. Second, depress your shoulder girdle as much as possible by pushing your shoulders away from your ears. Third, tense your abdominals and curl your pelvis as if you are trying to touch your shoulders with your toes. (You want your hips/groin to point upward as much as possible.) Lean back on your arms while simultaneously pushing your hands backwards, into the ground. Spread your legs as far apart as possible and lift them off the ground to the furthest angle you are able. Once your legs are almost vertical, push your hips forward aggressively. You can think of this in terms of either pushing your hips forward, or pushing your hands behind you as far as you are able. Now, dig your fingers into the ground and focus on pushing your hips toward the ceiling and pulling your knees toward your face as hard as you can to maximize compression.

Getting your hips above shoulder height is by far the most difficult part of the manna. You may be able to hold the manna if you jump into it or kick up into it—even if you cannot press into it. If your compression and hamstring flexibility has progressed sufficiently and merely needs to be maintained, make sure you do that from this point forward.

Continue working on your press into the manna. The strength built from this technique will assist in injury prevention, continue to improve your strength in extension, reinforce proper fundamental positions, and aid you with working progressions beyond this. Speed pushes and regular, slow, controlled pushes should make up the majority of your work at this point. If you need a little more help, you can use a spotter to help your hips get that last little bit, or do eccentrics from the high holds.

Getting the last 25 degrees will probably be the most frustrating work you will do compared to all of the other holds. Keep plugging away—if you obtain it, you will have one of the most rare static strength skills in the world (and healthy shoulders).

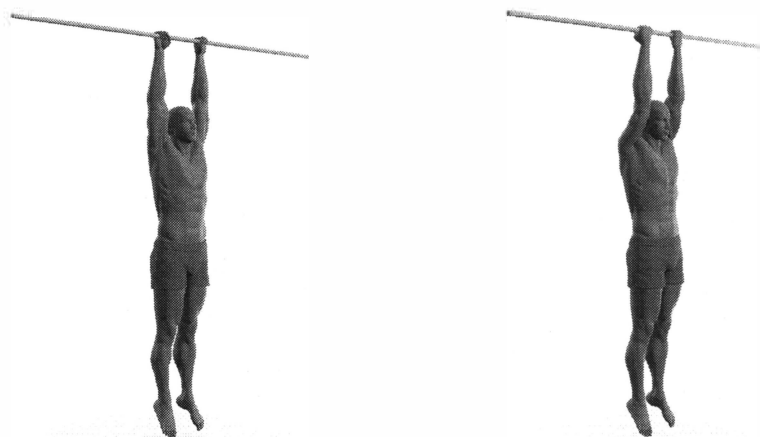
This is a C-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

Back Lever – Page 2, Column 1

Grip

In gymnastics-based strength training, the *back lever* is one of the first static strength-based movements you will learn. Working toward a solid back lever will prepare your body for many of the higher-level strength progressions, such as the iron cross.

You can execute the back lever on either a pull-up bar or rings. The difficulty level is roughly the same, so the choice is yours based on personal preference and availability of equipment. When using the bar, remember to set your hands correctly from the start since they are fixed. The recommended hand position is the chin-up position (hands facing toward you). You can modify your grip on the rings during the movement as needed.



Pronated Grip (Overhand) vs. Supinated Grip (Underhand)

When using a fixed bar, grab the bar with a palms-facing-you grip (supinated grip). Slide your body up (between your arms) and back down, flipped around. When using the rings, your hand positioning does not matter until after you are inverted. (Your palms will naturally face your body.) Once you begin to lower into a back lever position, supinate your grip and have your palms face the same direction as your body.

Supinated grip improves strength in your elbow connective tissues and allows you to recruit more of your biceps, both of which will be important in later progressions. Even if you do not have any pre-existing injury conditions you may at first experience discomfort in your elbows. This is normal. To counteract this and help protect your joints, strongly tense your biceps during the hold.

When beginning with this isometric exercise some elbow soreness is to be expected from the stress mentioned above, but if you have elbow injury issues like excessive hyperextension or previous injuries that may be aggravated, you may need to back off and perform extra prehabilitation.

In regard to prehabilitation and overuse injuries, always first eliminate the offending exercise(s) and replace it/them with non-painful mobility work and isolation biceps work for a week or two. This is often enough time to fix the issue and you can continue from there. Second, understand that your ego might be

in the way, and you may need to lower the intensity by stepping down in the progression. This is important if you have not been using supinated grip or have been progressing too fast (in which case the pain is likely caused by too much intensity). Thirdly, realize that isolation work may be necessary, typically biceps curls, which will strengthen your biceps and connective tissues at your elbow. For connective tissue soreness, higher repetitions seem to be most advantageous—specifically in the range of twenty to fifty repetitions. Aim for two to four sets as supplementary work.

If your injury condition or concerns are extreme enough and the benefits of supination in back lever do not align strongly with your goals, simply do not use the supinated grip.

GERMAN HANG – LEVEL 1



Scapular Positioning: When relaxed, your scapulas will be elevated and retracted. If you activate your shoulders, they will be either depressed and neutral or slightly retracted.

Technique: When on the bar or rings, pull yourself through your arms and slowly lower into the German hang position. Ideally, your hands should be supinated the entire time.

The *German hang* is one of the fundamental positions in gymnastics. It is primarily used to extensively stretch out your shoulders for more advanced skills like the manna. It is one of the primary starting positions used to condition elbow and shoulder connective tissues for more advanced rings and bar skills. If you can become accustomed to using a supinated grip, you will benefit greatly in the long run. It is also a good stretch if your shoulders are inflexible.

Sometimes a German hang may be too much for beginner's shoulders or elbows to take. If this is the case, try performing it with a raised implement to take some of the weight, such as a box to rest your feet upon. Alternatively, if you are using rings, you can lower them so your feet are on the floor. Both of these options are effective to reduce the weight on your upper body by assisting your lower body. Slowly work your way into the full hang position without any lower-body assistance.

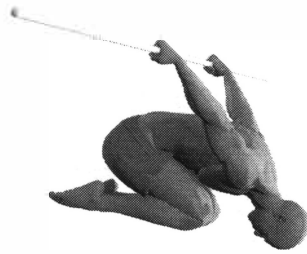
SKIN THE CAT – LEVEL 2

Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will begin protracted in an inverted pike position, or depressed in an inverted hang position. They will elevate as you move into the German hang position, but will not elevate all the way if you keep your shoulders active. As you move back up to the inverted hang or inverted pike position, your scapulas will begin to depress again.

Technique: Begin on the rings or bar in an inverted pike or inverted hang position (straight-body inverted pike). Enter the German hang position by bending at your hips in a slow and controlled manner. You may need to bend your knees for more control. When you reach the bottom of the movement, relax and feel the stretch. Next, activate your shoulders and pull yourself back up to the inverted pike or inverted hang position with your legs in a pike position. You can tuck to make this easier.

Skin the Cat is a colloquial term used in gymnastics for moving in and out of the German hang. It builds flexibility and strength in your shoulders for the back lever and other upper-level movements. Adding this to the back lever progression with the German hang makes it more beginner-friendly. This movement will enable you to build flexibility and strength in your shoulders and elbows and will condition your connective tissues as you build up to the back lever and more advanced movements.

TUCK BACK LEVER – LEVEL 3



Scapular Positioning: The scapulas will begin depressed and neutral—neither protracted nor retracted. Protracting your scapulas tends to round your chest, while retracting them tends to arch your back. Both of these positions are undesirable.

Technique: Your knees should be tucked against your chest, using your abdominals and hip flexors to pull them up. As soon as your hips reach exactly shoulder level (specifically your greater trochanter—the hard bone on the outside of your hip), hold the position. If you are moving into a tuck back lever from another position, lower yourself into the position and tense your body harder to hold the position.

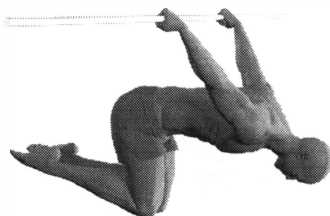
The *tuck back lever* (which can be abbreviated *Tuck BL*) is the simplest of the back lever progressions. This isometric hold can also be turned into a movement to work your muscle range of motion. You can slowly lower from an inverted hanging position into the tuck back lever position. From the inverted tuck position, begin to tense your pectorals, latissimus dorsi, and anterior shoulder. This should allow you to control your body as you allow yourself to slowly descend backward. This will also prime important muscles to stay tense during the movement for control purposes.

There are two common faults during this movement that hinder proper strength development:

1. Making the movement easier by pulling your arms in toward your body and squeezing your lats harder. This may help if you are weak starting out and cannot hold the position well. However, you will want to eliminate this habit as you improve, as it tends to retract your scapulas and cause your back to arch.
2. Allowing your chest to round forward. This contributes to a curled torso in later progressions and provides a mechanical advantage that ignores building strength properly in the first place. Additionally, this caveman-like posture is not aesthetically pleasing. Eliminate it now so you will not have to correct it down the road.

If you are having issues holding the position, you can work negatives from an inverted hang to a German hang, as well as full-range movements like pulling out from the German hang position, back to an inverted hang position. Working pull-ups and rowing progressions may also ease the development of back lever isometrics. Essentially, if you are having trouble holding the static position, supplement it with dynamic work.

ADVANCED TUCK BACK LEVER – LEVEL 4



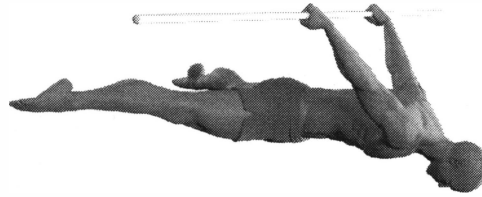
Scapular Positioning: The scapulas will begin depressed and neutral. They will not be protracted or retracted. Protracting your scapulas tends to round your chest, while retracting them tends to arch your back. Both of these positions are undesirable.

Technique: This skill is performed by contracting your back muscles to straighten out your rounded torso. For the standard tuck back lever, you pull your knees to your chest and allow your back to round. However, for the advanced tuck back lever, you need to straighten your core—from your shoulders, through your body, to your hips. Aim for a 90 degree angle made by your torso and thighs.

The *advanced tuck back lever* (which can be abbreviated *Adv. Tuck BL*) is a continuation of the advanced tuck. Since you are straightening out your torso, you will increase the difficulty by pushing your center of mass slightly farther away from your shoulders, increasing torque at your joints. If this progression becomes easy for you to hold, open your hip angle by moving your knees further away from your chest. You want to work up to hip and knee angles of ninety degrees each. The technique to perform this skill is the same as the tuck back lever. Remember to keep a supinated grip, a proud chest, and do not squeeze your hands closer to each other. The increased torque at your shoulder will put more torque at your elbow. This increased stress may lead to soreness. Fixing the issue is the same as previously described for the tuck back lever.

To make the skill slightly easier or slightly harder you can use ankle weights, or a weighted vest, or vary your thigh positioning with a straight back. This will help you regress (if you need to) or advance to reach the next level of the progression.

STRADDLE BACK LEVER – LEVEL 5



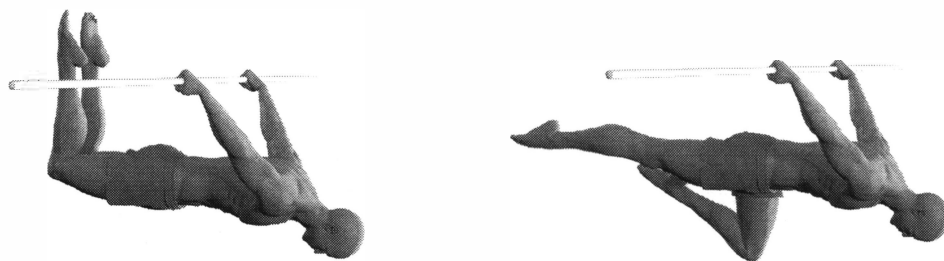
Scapular Positioning: The scapulas will begin depressed and neutral. They will not be protracted or retracted. Protracting your scapulas tends to round your chest, while retracting them tends to arch your back. Both of these positions are undesirable.

Technique: To execute this skill, you will straddle while in an inverted hang position and then lower into a back lever. Alternatively, you can lower into one of the tuck positions and then extend your body out into a straddle position. While your previous goal was to align your hips with your shoulders, you now want to facilitate alignment of your entire body—from your hips, to your knees, to your toes.

The quality of the *straddle back lever position* (which can be abbreviated *Straddle BL*) depends greatly on the quality of your straddle. By now, you should be working compression, straddle-L, and perhaps various press handstand progressions that require better flexibility.

If you have not been practicing your straddle position under stress like this, it is likely that your hip region will cramp. Tolerate as much as you can while performing the hold, until you reach the point where you are at risk of falling. The cramps will dissipate quickly as you train. (See Chapter 21 for more about muscle cramps.)

Technique remains the same as you are simply moving your center of mass further out. This will increase the torque at your shoulders, which makes the movement harder, and it will also increase the torque at your elbows, which will put more pressure on your joints. Fixing this issue is same as previously prescribed, although it may take longer with the increased stress.

HALF LAYOUT / ONE-LEG-OUT BACK LEVER – LEVEL 6

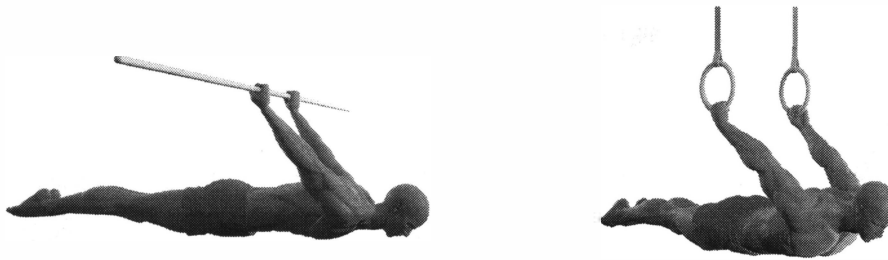
Scapular Positioning: The scapulas will begin depressed and neutral. They will not be protracted or retracted. Protracting your scapulas tends to round your chest, while retracting them tends to arch your back. Both of these positions are undesirable.

Technique: In the half layout position, all of your joints are aligned—except your knees, which are bent at a ninety-degree angle. As opposed to the straddle position, your legs are drawn in and touching one another. For the one-leg-out position, you will have one leg out and fully straight from hip to toe, while your other leg is tucked in as tightly as possible without compromising the position of your torso. The toe of your bent leg should touch the knee of your straight leg.

Both of these positions approximate a center of mass that is further out than the straddle back lever. Depending on your body awareness you can go with one of these positions to increase difficulty before transitioning to the full back lever. The half layout position is preferred, provided you can keep good body positioning. Aligning both knees with your hips is important for maintaining good body awareness, which will come in handy in other techniques. This position is harder to maintain, though, so most beginners will use the one-leg-out position. When possible, work both to progress toward the full back lever.

Remember, increases in torque at your shoulders make the movement harder, and increased torque at your elbows will put more pressure on your joints. To address this issue, see the recommendation given in the previous back lever sections.

FULL BACK LEVER – LEVEL 7



Scapular Positioning: The scapulas will begin depressed and neutral. They will not be protracted or retracted. Protracting your scapulas tends to round your chest, while retracting them tends to arch your back. Both of these positions are undesirable.

Technique: Hold your body straight and squeeze all of your muscles in order to generate tension—especially your core, glutes, and quads. Lock your scapulas in place and pull your hands toward your hips while keeping your head in a neutral position. You may find that if you squeeze your glutes too hard, they may appear slightly arched (like in one of the images above). Try to avoid this.

Technique for the *full back lever* (which can be abbreviated *Full BL*) is just like the straddle back lever, only your legs are closed and touching. Your shoulders should line up with your hips, which should line up with your knees, which should line up with your ankles, which should line up with your pointed toes. Your body should be perfectly parallel with the ground.

At this point, the most common technique flaw is rounding your back and hunching your shoulders. Ideally, you are working out with a partner or have a camera to view this so you can self-correct. A mirror can also work if you have one available.

You have now progressed far enough to hold a static position that facilitates healthy shoulder flexibility and body awareness in a disadvantageous position. Also, you have acquired a great amount of both pulling and pressing strength. Congratulations!

This is an A-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

BACK LEVER PULLOUT – LEVEL 8



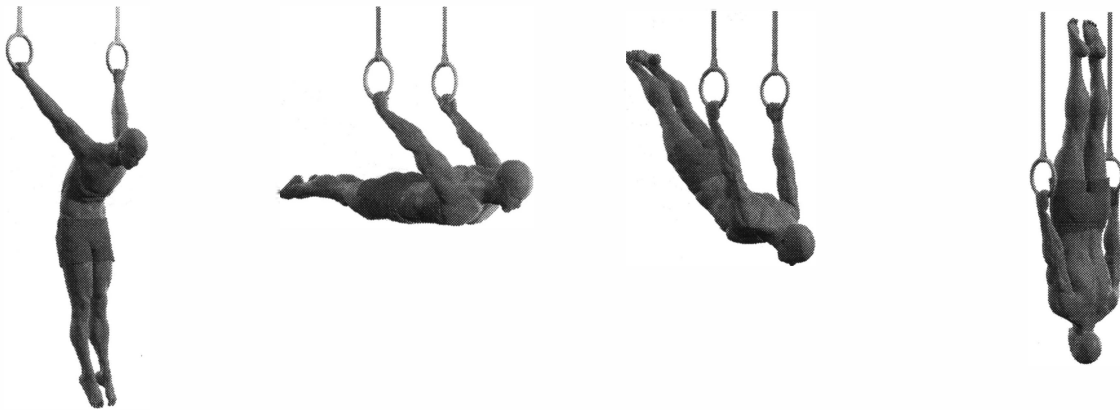
Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will begin depressed and neutral. They will not be protracted or retracted. Protracting your scapulas tends to round your chest, while retracting them tends to arch your back. Both of these positions are undesirable. Your scapulas should stay depressed and neutral throughout the entire pull.

Technique: Begin in a straight-body back lever position by lowering into it, jumping into it, or moving into it from a German hang or from one of the previous progressions. Keep your body straight as you pull your hands toward your hips. Your feet will begin to rise toward the inverted hang position. Keep pulling until you reach that position. The technique above is shown with a neutral grip. Start with this grip and transition to a supinated grip once you get the hang of it, as the supinated grip is good for your biceps and elbow connective tissues.

You are now in a transition from holds to movements. Your muscles are strongest in eccentric movements, weaker in isometric movements, and weakest in concentric movements. Training the concentric portion of a movement after learning an isometric will require more strength of you and subsequently build more strength.

When performing a *back lever pullout* (which can be abbreviated *BL Pullout*), try not to tense all of your back muscles without doing the same for your chest and abdominals, as doing so may cause your spine to arch. You want to avoid this kind of pulling and rely solely on the strength from your pectorals, lats, and anterior shoulder to move your body. It may help to think about moving your center of mass (around your hips) above your head. Thinking about moving your toes above your head will typically cause your back to arch, so remember to move from your center of mass.

GERMAN HANG PULLOUT – LEVEL 9



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will begin elevated. Contract your muscles to depress them and initiate the movement. They will stay depressed and neutral throughout the entire pull.

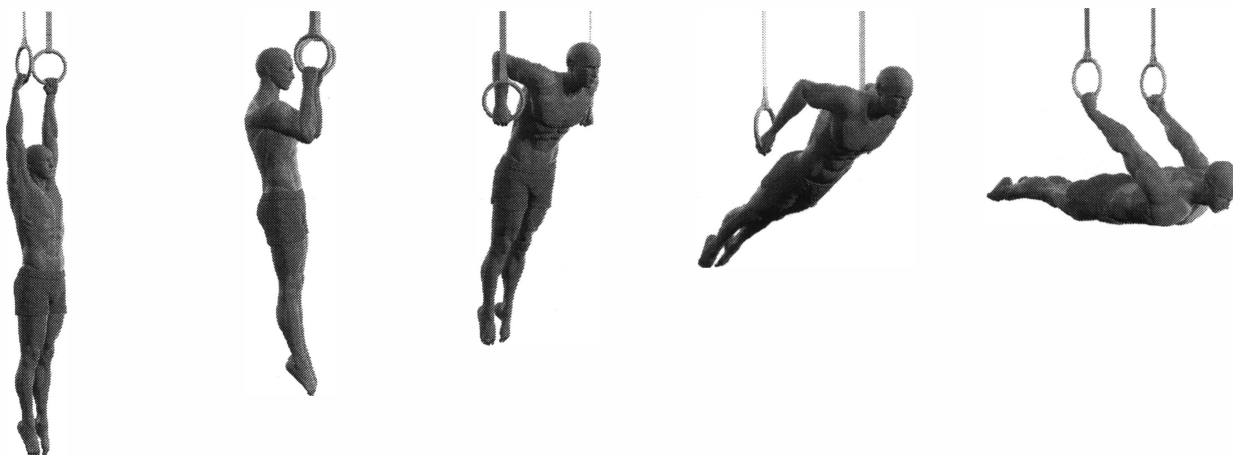
Technique: Begin in the German hang position. Next, straighten your body so that your upper back is not rounded. Keep your body straight as you pull your hands toward your hips. Your feet will begin to rise toward the inverted hang position. Keep pulling until you reach that position. The technique above is shown with a neutral grip. Start with this grip and transition to a supinated grip when you are able to, as the supinated grip is good for your biceps and elbow connective tissues.

The *German hang pullout* (which can be abbreviated *GH Pullout*) takes the back lever pullout to another level by increasing the range of motion. This skill begins from a full German hang, with your shoulders relaxed. From this point straighten your body and then initiate the strength portion of the skill. After your body is straight and rigid, use that disadvantaged shoulder angle to pull—slowly and controlled—all the way back to an inverted hang.

It is very common to use the bit of momentum from initially straightening your body to assist in accelerating the bottom portion of this movement, thus making it easier and losing strength gains. Avoid this and pull through the movement with your shoulders alone.

It may help to think about moving your center of mass (found near your hips) to above your head; thinking about moving your toes typically causes your back to arch.

BENT-ARM PULL-UP TO BACK LEVER – LEVEL 10



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will begin elevated, in the hang position. They will depress and retract slightly as you initiate the pull-up and begin rotating. As you complete the half muscle-up position, they want to naturally retract further. Do not allow this to happen. Once you descend to the back lever position, your scapulas will end depressed and neutral.

Technique: Begin in the hang position on the rings. Perform a pull-up and the muscle-up transition by rowing your elbows back behind you. Subsequently, lean forward and slowly extend your arms until they are straight as you move toward the back lever position.

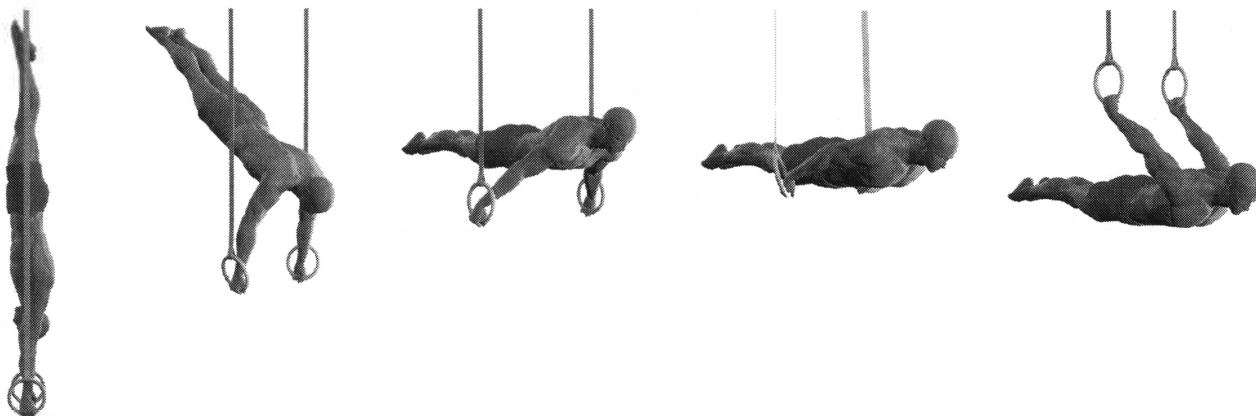
The *bent-arm pull-up to back lever* (which can be abbreviated *BA Pull-up to BL*) is slightly different from the traditional back lever progressions, however, it ends in a back lever position and is an authentic pulling skill progression that uses strengths that the back lever fosters.

First, pull up to the top position of a pull-up (elbows can be in or out; your choice). Begin leaning forward into the transition of a muscle-up. At this point, rotate your hands out and backward so that your palms face straight behind you. While you are rotating your hands, allow your feet to move backward so that your body moves closer to being parallel with the ground. From there, use your chest and lats to control the skill as your body straightens and extends into the back lever position.

This skill is not particularly difficult to comprehend or perform. The main issues that come with this skill is the level of force it places on your shoulders and elbows, especially during the rotation of the rings outward and the straightening of your arms into the back lever position. If you experience significant discomfort or pain you should avoid this skill until you have increased your level of strength or conditioned your joints and connective tissues.

This is a B-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

HANDSTAND LOWER TO BACK LEVER – LEVEL 11



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas begin elevated, in a handstand position. As you move through the planche and maltese positions they transition to depressed and protracted. When you end in a back lever, they will be depressed and neutral.

Technique: The handstand lower to back lever begins in a rings handstand. As you lower, push your shoulders forward. You will then reach a semi-elbow lever position on the rings. From there, lower with your body parallel to the ground at rings height. Your arms should be bent while you do this. Slowly extend your arms until they are straight and you hit the back lever position. Essentially, this skill involves lowering to an elbow lever, then straight through a bent-arm maltese position (straight body, level with the rings), down into a back lever.

The *handstand lower to back lever* (which can be abbreviated as *HS Lower to BL*) is an interesting skill. It is a dual pushing/pulling skill, but it fits here with the back lever progressions.

Like the previous skill, one thing that may cause problems is the “fall.” If you are not strong enough to lower slowly under control, your body will jerk when you reach the back lever position. This movement can be tough on your shoulders and elbows. If this is the case it may be a good idea to back off and focus on more on strength work, and use assistance devices or a spotter.

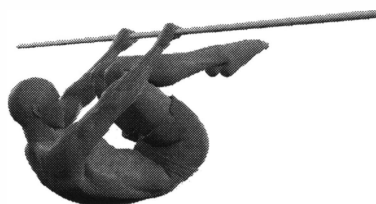
This is a B-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

Front Lever – Page 2, Column 2

The front lever is a secondary static skill. These progressions will be a bit more difficult as denoted on the strength progression charts. This is because your lats are lengthened slightly, and your pectoral muscles are in a shorter position than normal. As you know, muscles are strongest around the middle of their range of motion.

The front lever should be trained with or after the back lever. It will build a solid foundation for advanced rings strength skills. (It looks pretty cool, too.)

TUCK FRONT LEVER – LEVEL 4



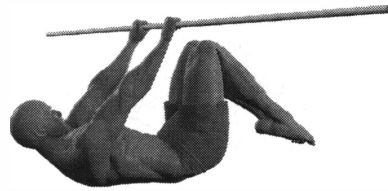
Scapular Positioning: There is often confusion with scapular positioning for the front lever. In the front lever position, your scapulas will be in a depressed and neutral position. To prevent them from being depressed and protracted you will need to pull hard until they are depressed and retracted. The result of this is that they will end in a depressed and neutral position.

Technique: Begin in a hang position and pull up into a front lever position with straight or bent arms. Level off your hips with your shoulders while your knees are tucked to your chest. Push your hands forward toward your hips to hold this position.

When performing the *tuck front lever* (which can be abbreviated *Tuck FL*), you can apply pressure from your hands with either a parallel or pronated grip. Though it is entirely a personal preference, using a pronated grip will allow you to practice on a wide variety of surfaces (bars, stairwells, doorposts, tree limbs, and the like). This will make it much easier to find a place to practice in the event that you go out of town, for example, and this can help you stay consistent in your training.

As noted in the technique section above, one of the key points is to pull your shoulder blades down and together while you apply downward pressure on the rings or bar. This creates a good “packed shoulder” position and activates all of your musculature through your torso, giving you a leverage advantage.

ADVANCED TUCK FRONT LEVER – LEVEL 5



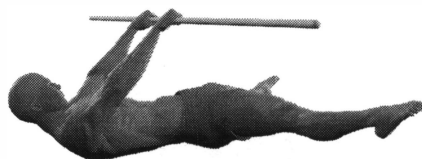
Scapular Positioning: There is often confusion with scapular positioning for the front lever. In the front lever position, your scapulas will be in a depressed and neutral position. To prevent them from being depressed and protracted you will need to pull hard until they are depressed and retracted—they will end up in a depressed and neutral position.

Technique: This is performed like a standard tuck front lever, but you straighten out your back to increase torque on your shoulders. Once you can do this efficiently, move your knees off of your chest and get them out to a ninety-degree angle at your hips, and eventually a ninety-degree angle at your knees as well. This is the same torso position that you will use for the front lever.

The next progression is the *advanced tuck front lever* (which can be abbreviated *Adv. Tuck FL*). If you are not strong enough to perform this yet, you can use eccentric exercises or concentric pullouts with the previous movements to help build enough strength for this isometric. (This will probably be unnecessary.) The pull is similar to the feeling of trying to force the bar to your hips or knees with your hands. Remember to squeeze your scapulas together while performing this movement.

Specific scapular work may be beneficial, however. You can hang from a bar or rings and shrug your shoulders up and down to work scapular depression. Likewise, *scapular pulls* are an exercise where you perform the shrugging motion and then try to tilt your chest toward the ceiling. These can be effective for strengthening your scapulas for the front lever positions.

STRADDLE FRONT LEVER – LEVEL 6



Scapular Positioning: There is often confusion with scapular positioning for the front lever. In the front lever position, your scapulas will be in a depressed and neutral position. However, to prevent them from being depressed and protracted you will need to pull hard until they are depressed and retracted. The result of this effort is that they will end in a depressed and neutral position.

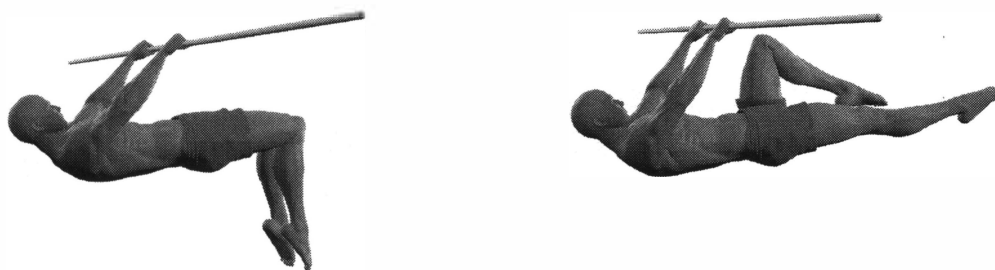
Technique: This skill is performed by straddling your legs as far apart as possible, and then aligning your shoulder joint with your hip joint, knees and ankles while you keep your back straight. Your body will appear straight from the side. Beginners may find that their torso rounds – a position that makes the hold wrong. You must keep your torso flat. If this increases the difficulty too much, work on eccentrics or concentric pullouts from the previous progression in order to move up to this skill.

Proficiency with the *straddle front lever* (which can be abbreviated *Straddle FL*) depends a lot on how well you can perform the straddle. If you have not yet begun to work compression and the straddle L-sit, start them now. If you have not been practicing a straddle position under stress, it is likely that you will experience cramping in your hip region. Tolerate the cramps as best as possible while performing the hold. They are a terrible annoyance and you might curse the world, but stick with it and get back up into the position. The cramps will dissipate as you continue training.

Key weaknesses seen in people trying to progress beyond advanced tuck front lever are usually not found in their primary muscles (the pectorals and lats). Instead, problems arise from their stabilizers in the posterior shoulder and scapulas. If these muscles are weak, as they typically are, they can limit force output at the shoulders. The body will inhibit force production if it deems that extra force will cause a joint to become unstable.

Specific attention to the back of the shoulder is usually needed to solve this issue (and in any event, it helps keep your shoulders healthy). Manna progressions are a wonderful training tool, as they strengthen the musculature in your posterior shoulder and train compression, both of which are needed for the straddle front lever and many other movements/holds as well. If you have started working toward the manna but have not paid much attention to it, or have not started yet, take a step back on front lever work and focus on the manna.

HALF LAYOUT / ONE-LEG-OUT FRONT LEVER – LEVEL 7



Scapular Positioning: There is often confusion with scapular positioning for the front lever. In the front lever position, your scapulas will be in a depressed and neutral position. However, to prevent them from being depressed and protracted you will need to pull hard until they are depressed and retracted. The result of this effort is that they will end in a depressed and neutral position.

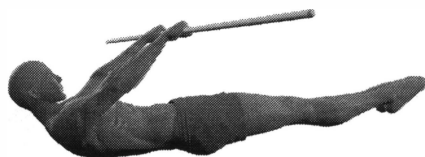
Technique: In the half layout position, all of your joints are aligned—with the exception of your knees, which are bent at a ninety-degree angle. As opposed to the straddle position, your legs are drawn in and touching one another. For the one-leg-out position, you will have one leg out and fully straight from hip to toe, while your other leg is tucked in as tightly as possible without compromising the position of your torso. The toe of your bent leg usually touches the knee of your straight leg.

Both of these positions push your center of mass farther out than the straddle back lever, so depending on your body awareness, you can go with one of these positions to increase difficulty before transitioning to the full front lever.

The half layout position is preferred provided you can keep good body positioning, since aligning both knees with your hips is important to maintaining good body awareness and will come in handy in other techniques. This position is harder to maintain, so most will use the one-leg-out position. When possible, work both to prepare for the full front lever.

The most common technique flaws in this position are the same ones you will encounter with the straddle front lever—sagging or bent hips, a rounded chest, or weakness in the back near your scapulas. Target the areas where you are weak in order to progress to the next level in your training.

FULL FRONT LEVER – LEVEL 8



Scapular Positioning: There is often confusion with scapular positioning for the front lever. In the front lever position, your scapulas will be in a depressed and neutral position. However, to prevent them from being depressed and protracted you will need to pull hard until they are depressed and retracted. The result of this effort is that they will end in a depressed and neutral position.

Technique: This hold requires a straight body from shoulders to torso to hips to knees to ankles and to toes (which should be pointed). It is important to get full-body tension before sliding into this skill, as it will help make this hold easier and more consistent.

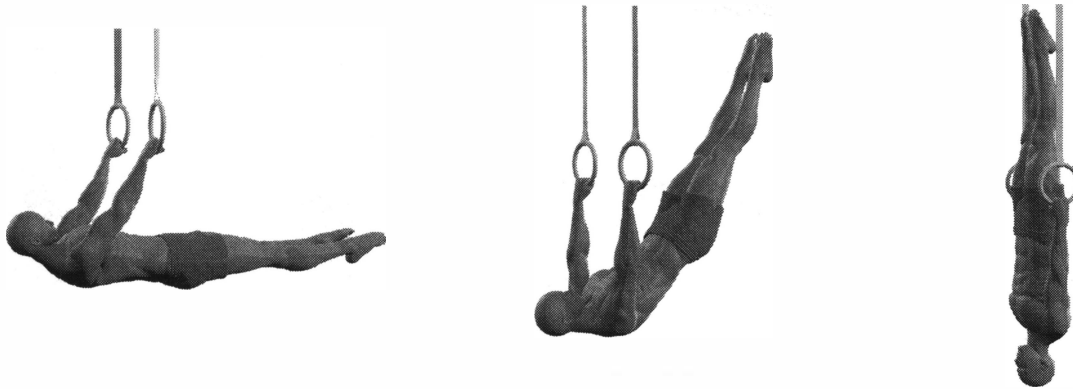
Like the previous progressions, the most common technique flaw when performing the *full front lever* (which can be abbreviated *Full FL*) is rounding your back—including your shoulders—to unknowingly obtain mechanical advantages. Ideally, a partner or camera can provide insight so you can improve your form, but a mirror is also a viable option. Here are some other tips that may be valuable:

- Consider utilizing eccentric movements. For example, inverted hang slow eccentrics to front lever or hang position can build strength for the front lever.
- Front lever responds particularly well to supplementary posterior shoulder strengthening, as well as a wide combination of overall strengthening. This may include specific scapular and rotator cuff work.
- Front lever pull-ups are another good supplementary exercise.
- Very heavy deadlifts work the front lever movement fairly well. Pinning the bar into your shins while you are rising up from the start of the deadlift translates very well. Very strong athletes from other sports have been able to perform a front lever without any practice at all.
- Dragon flags may help if you have particular torso or core weakness. It can help improve shoulder strength to keep your arms straight while performing dragon flags.

Unlike the front lever, there are many different exercises that help develop the full front lever, so you can approach it from many different pathways and be successful.

This is an A-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

FRONT LEVER PULL TO INVERTED HANG – LEVEL 9

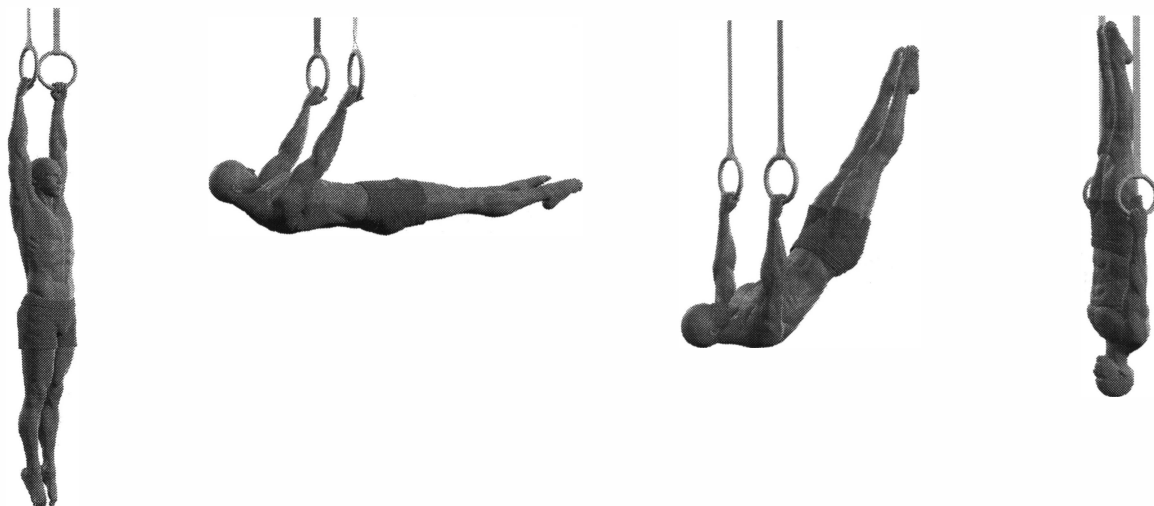


Scapular Positioning: There is often confusion with scapular positioning for the front lever. In the front lever position, your scapulas will be in a depressed and neutral position. However, to prevent them from being depressed and protracted you will need to pull hard until they are depressed and retracted. The result of this effort is that they will end in a depressed and neutral position. As you move into the inverted hang position, your scapulas should stay neutral and depressed the entire time; only your shoulder should move.

Technique: Begin in a front lever position. Squeeze your entire body tightly, especially your core, glutes, and legs. Then, pull your hands toward your hips as hard as you can while maintaining straight-body positioning. End in an inverted hang position.

Contrary to the back lever, the difficulty with the *front lever pull to inverted hang* (which can be abbreviated *FL to Inv.*) lies in trying to overcome the tendency to tense the muscles on the front of your body. This will round the torso and close your hip angle. You want to avoid this type of pulling and rely solely on the strength from your pectorals, lats, and posterior shoulder to move your body.

Working this movement in conjunction with the eccentrics can help you bridge the gap even after you have obtained the front lever isometric itself. Work the movement in reverse with the eccentric and you will eventually get strong in the concentric portion. Other tips from the front lever section will also be effective.

HANG PULL TO INVERTED HANG – LEVEL 10

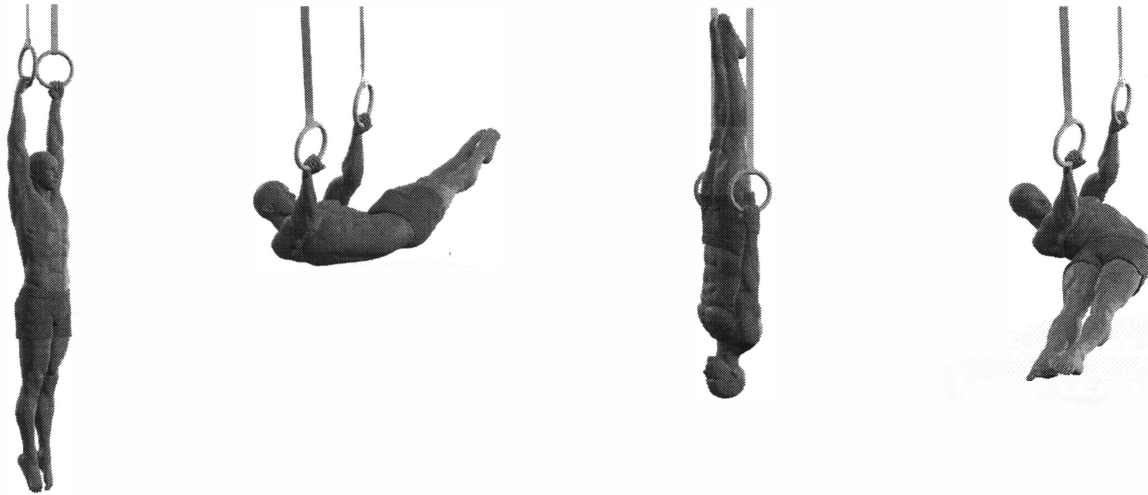
Scapular Positioning: Begin in a hang position, with your scapulas elevated. Then, depress your scapulas to activate your shoulder. As you begin to ascend to the front lever and inverted hang positions, focus on keeping your scapulas depressed and strongly retracted. It is likely that they will look depressed and neutral because of the pull, which is fine.

Technique: Begin in a hang position. Squeeze your entire body tightly, especially your core, glutes, and legs. Then, pull your hands toward your hips as hard as you can while maintaining straight-body positioning. End in an inverted hang position.

It is very tempting to use the bit of momentum from the initiation of the *hang pull to inverted hang* (which can be abbreviated *Hang Pull to Inv.*) to assist you in accelerating out of the bottom of the movement. You can do this at first if needed, but work toward phasing it out. Your goal is to strengthen your shoulder muscles to the point where you do not need momentum.

Scapular pulls are extremely useful when training this exercises because they focus on pulling with your shoulders in the correct position. The movement is typically limited by a lack of scapular strength, so address this area of weakness if you are having trouble performing this movement without momentum.

CIRCLE FRONT LEVERS – LEVEL 11



Scapular Positioning: Begin in a hang position, with your scapulas elevated. Then, depress your scapulas to activate your shoulder. As you begin to ascend to the front lever and inverted hang positions, focus on keeping your scapulas depressed and strongly retracted. It is likely that they will look depressed and neutral because of the pull, which is fine.

Technique: Begin in a hang position and imagine a human-sized clock in front of you. Your feet will act as the hands on this clock. Keeping your body aligned in the same plane as your arms, pull your legs to one side. If doing the left side, move your feet with a straight body to the 7:00 position. Continue to 8:00, 9:00, 10:00, 11:00 and finally the inverted position at 12:00. Next, lower all the way to 6:00 in a slow and controlled manner. Make sure to perform both sides of the clock for balanced development.

As a potential intermediate step before working *circle front levers* (which can be abbreviated *Circle FLs*), you can move side to side in the front lever position. This may be more accessible than a circular motion at first. Essentially, you will draw a horizontal line across the horizon with your feet.

Overall, this movement is most useful as a further progression past the full front lever hang to inverted hang pull. At that point, your body cannot be straightened any further to decrease leverage, and a full movement is already possible, so this is the next feasible way to increase the challenge factor. While it can be done with a lower level progression, it is unnecessary at those levels.

As you improve at these, you can go out wider to the sides. Alternatively, a weight vest or ankle weights may be used to increase difficulty.

Front Lever Rows – Page 2, Column 3

Front lever rows are a favorite horizontal pulling exercise and are highly recommended to keep your shoulders balanced. Performed in combination with the L-sit/V-sit/manna progression (and potentially adding in a horizontal rowing exercise), this movement will easily keep your shoulders well balanced.

TUCK FRONT LEVER ROWS – LEVEL 5



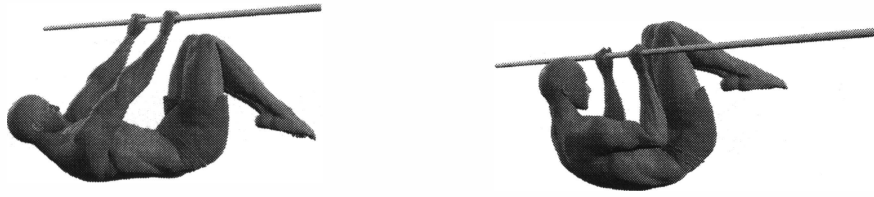
Scapular Positioning: Begin in a tuck front lever position, with your scapulas depressed and neutral. You will have to retract them in order to keep them in a neutral position. As you pull your hips toward the bar, keep your scapulas depressed and retract them further, moving all the way to the fully retracted position. As you lower back down to the starting position, keep your scapulas fully depressed but allow them to protract back to a neutral position.

Technique: The tuck front lever row starting position is identical to the tuck front lever static position. Align your hips with your shoulders and keep them parallel to the ground. In the tuck position, your torso will be rounded and your knees will be tucked to your chest. Continue to keep your hips and shoulders aligned and parallel to the ground as you initiate the pull. Drive your elbows down until the bar reaches your shins, then return to the start position in a controlled manner.

When performing *tuck front lever rows* (which can be abbreviated *Tuck FL Pull*), your range of motion will be short because your shins will hit the bar. You can avoid this by performing this movement on parallel bars instead. Do not fall victim to the most common mistake: dropping your hips. Be extra sure to keep your shoulders and hips in a straight line, and that line parallel with the ground. The second most common mistake is allowing your shoulders to protract all the way, which generally signals weakness in your scapular retractors. This happens to almost everyone, but specific scapular retraction placed at the end of your routine when working this progression can help.

Some people will tell you to think about the pulling motion as pulling your hands toward your hips—or, in this progression, to your shins. The elbows analogy is preferred because the common fault is to allow your hips to drop and your torso to become more upright. Thinking about your elbows forces your torso to stay parallel to the ground. It is an easy way to stay on track to performing the technique correctly.

ADVANCED TUCK FRONT LEVER ROWS – LEVEL 6



Scapular Positioning: Begin in an advanced tuck front lever position, with your scapulas depressed and neutral. You will have to retract them in order to keep them in a neutral position. As you pull your hips toward the bar, keep your scapulas depressed and retract them further, moving all the way to the fully retracted position. As you lower back down to the starting position, keep your scapulas fully depressed but allow them to protract back to a neutral position.

Technique: Begin in an advanced tuck front lever position. Align your hips with your shoulders and keep them parallel to the ground. In the advanced tuck position, your torso will be straight and your hips bent at a ninety-degree angle. From there, continue to keep your hips and shoulders aligned and parallel to the ground as you initiate the pull. Drive your elbows down until the bar reaches your hips, and then return to the start position in a controlled manner.

The *advanced tuck front lever rows* (which can be abbreviated *Adv Tuck FL Pull*) progression affords a greater range of motion than the previous tuck front lever row progression because your shins are not in the way of the pull. This means that you may be on this progression longer. As you get stronger you will continue to increase your range of motion in this skill. Attempt ultimately to bring the bar to your stomach.

When you start this progression, it is common to have difficulty getting to or maintaining full range of motion. If you find yourself stalling out a couple inches from the bar, it is likely due to a lack of strength—either because of weak scapular muscles or weak biceps. If you have issues with maintaining the height of your hips, this is a problem with maintaining consistent pull toward your hips with your hands during the entire movement.

As you progress, you will slowly improve your ability to pull higher and more consistently over sets. Continue to work on this. Pull explosively using a 10x0 tempo. If you need specific scapular, back, or biceps work to supplement the rows, add some near the end of your workouts.

STRADDLE FRONT LEVER ROWS – LEVEL 8



Scapular Positioning: Begin in a straddle front lever position, with your scapulas depressed and neutral. You will have to retract them in order to keep them in a neutral position. As you pull your hips toward the bar, keep your scapulas depressed and retract them further, moving all the way to the fully retracted position. As you lower back down to the starting position, keep your scapulas fully depressed but allow them to protract back to a neutral position.

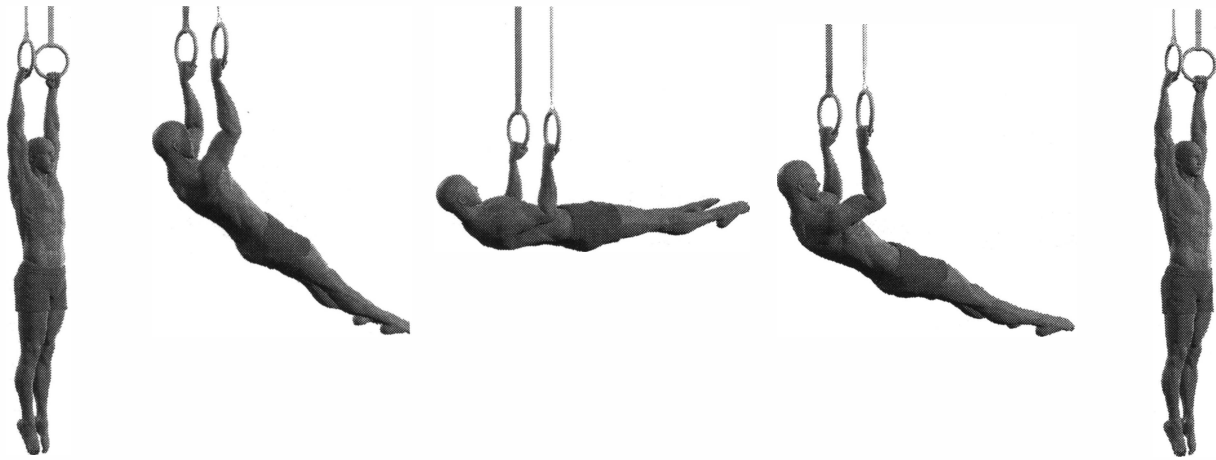
Technique: Begin in a straddle tuck front lever position. Align your hips with your shoulders and keep them parallel to the ground. In the straddle position, your shoulders will be in line with your hips and knees, but your legs will be spread apart. Keep your hips and shoulders aligned and parallel to the ground as you initiate the pull. Drive your elbows down until the bar reaches your hips, and then return to the start position in a controlled manner.

There are two common faults when attempting *straddle front lever rows* (which can be abbreviated *Straddle FL Pull*). The first is rounding your back during execution of the skill. The second is not keeping your legs in line with your body. Instead of a straight line, your body becomes more of a curved shape, like a C.

Additional core compression or L-Sit/V-Sit/manna progression work may be needed to strengthen your abdominals if your legs cannot be held out parallel to the ground with your torso. If proper work has been established previously, this should not be a problem.

Range of motion to the hips can be very difficult with this movement. Even when you become very strong you may have trouble performing this exercise with your hands to your hips. Work up to the point where you can perform at least a couple repetitions with your hands to your hips, with your hands coming within a couple of inches from your hips for the remainder of the repetitions. Continue working your scapular retractors and back muscles to become stronger.

HANG TO FRONT LEVER ROW – LEVEL 9



Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas relaxed and elevated. Initiate the movement by depressing your scapulas. As your body comes up to the horizontal position, keep them depressed while retracting them. Then, as you move back down into the hang position, allow them to protract to neutral. Relax your scapulas at the bottom of the position before allowing them to elevate.

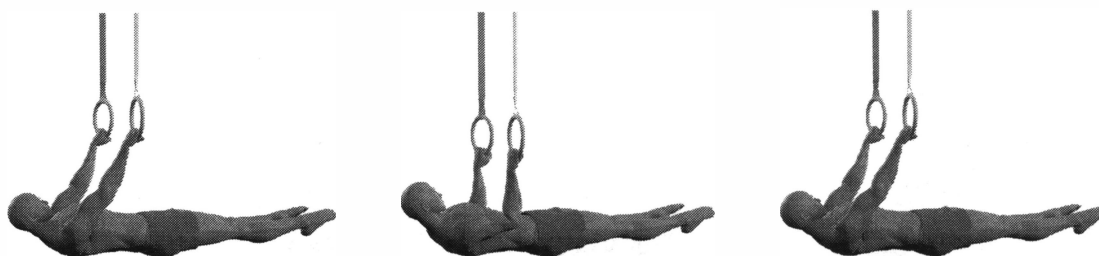
Technique: From a hang position, rotate your toes and hips forward as you bend your arms to lift your body up toward the rings. Continue leaning back while you bring your hands to your hips to hit the parallel position. Repeat these steps in reverse and under control to return to the hang position.

To perform the *hang to front lever row* (which can be abbreviated *Hang to FL Row*), begin from the hang position and perform a pull-up while simultaneously moving your body into the full front lever row position, ending with bent arms and your hands near your hips. Once you have pulled as far as possible, lower back to the point where you have the hang under control.

Normally, you want to avoid the use of momentum in any of your movements; however, this is one of a few exceptions. In the full or near-full front lever, pulling as it has been done in the previous progressions has very little range of motion. This approach allows more power and range of motion to be used, leading to a higher ending position than would be possible without momentum and an overall stronger back.

This approach is preferred over the half lay or one-leg-bent front lever row progression because of the multiple planes of movement it uses. It builds a greater awareness for hitting a good front lever row ending position, and it gets your posterior shoulder extensively involved in strength building.

FULL FRONT LEVER ROWS – LEVEL 10



Scapular Positioning: Begin in a front lever position, with your scapulas depressed and neutral. You will have to retract them in order to keep them in a neutral position. As you pull your hips toward the bar, keep your scapulas depressed and retract them further, moving all the way to the fully retracted position. As you lower back down to the starting position, keep your scapulas fully depressed but allow them to protract back to a neutral position.

Technique: Begin in a front lever position. Align your hips with your shoulders and keep them parallel to the ground. In the full front lever position, your shoulders will be in line with your hips and knees. From there, continue to keep your hips and shoulders aligned and parallel to the ground as you initiate the pull. Drive your elbows down until the bar reaches your hips, and then return to the start position in a controlled manner.

While performing *full front lever rows* (which can be abbreviated *Full FL Pull*), bend your torso or hollow your chest up toward the bar. You can eliminate this as you get stronger and more proficient in the movement, but it is to be expected for beginners. Your range of motion may not be that great—perhaps six to eight inches at best. However, if you have the strength to hold the isometric front lever position long enough, doing pulls in this position can act as a next-step-up.

Continue to progress the range of motion as much as possible. Alternatively, you can begin working this entire progression with a weighted vest, or move on to higher-level strength progressions.

ROPE CLIMB FRONT LEVER ROWS

Rope climbs are a very good exercise for building grip strength and facilitating the development of overall pulling strength. They very well could have their own category on the charts but as most bodyweight enthusiasts are likely going to be training from home, and acquiring a rope and finding a good place to put it can be tough, these exercises were folded into the *front lever rows* progression, which is one of many core exercises for horizontal pulling. If you do have access to a rope at a gymnastics gym, CrossFit gym, or any other facility that has ropes for use, adding in rope climbing in your strength and conditioning training is highly recommended, and more important for developing overall posterior shoulder girdle strength than every exercise aside from the *L-sit* → *mantra* progression. (The *rowing to one-arm row* progression is a close third.)

The rope climb progression interweaves very well with the front levers, as your hands are moved inward and additional grip strength is required. Just as the front lever row is one level of difficulty harder than the front lever isometrics by one progression, the rope climbing front lever row progression is one level of difficulty harder than the *PB/SR front lever row* progression.

One the chart, since there is not enough space for the tuck front lever row, only the advanced tuck, straddle, and full front lever row progressions are included.

Fortunately, the technique for the rope climb front lever row progressions are the same as their counterparts. The only difference is the position of the rope. The rope will typically be pulled from in front and will move off to the side of your body instead of going through your legs. (If you try it through your legs you may cause some very unpleasant sensations in your groin.)

Here are the approximate difficulty levels for the progressions:

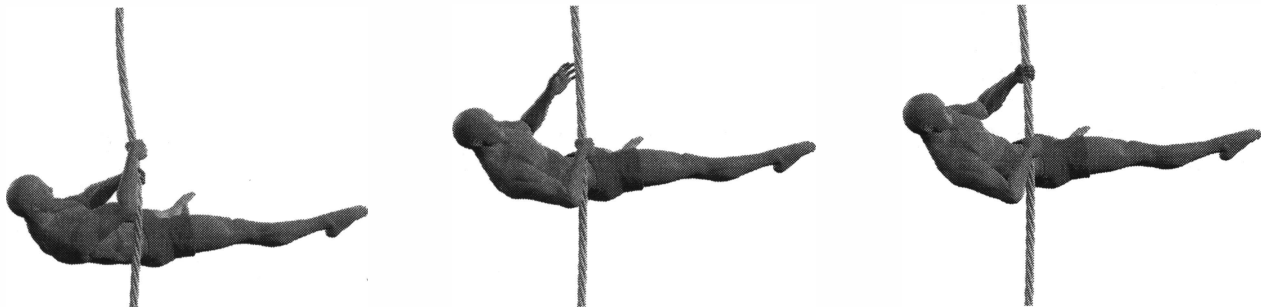
Tuck Front Lever Row Rope Climb – Level 6

Not shown.

Advanced Tuck Front Lever Row Rope Climb – Level 7



Straddle Front Lever Row Rope Climb – Level 9



Full Front Lever Row Rope Climb – Level 11

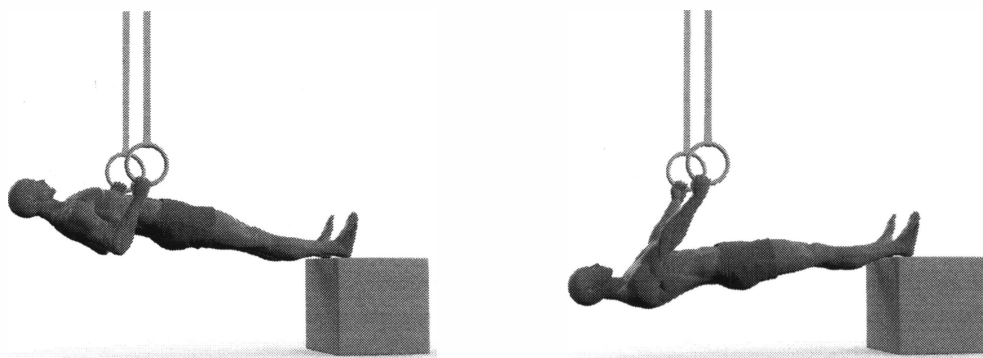


Rowing – Page 2, Column 4

Rowing progressions are useful when your ability is at a lower level. Rowing can easily build pulling strength and maintain balance within your shoulder girdle. They are wonderful for increasing strength until the front lever and manna progressions are built up. Plus: horizontal pulling is essential to keep your shoulders healthy.

Important Note: Those with any type of imbalance should focus on the upper portion of the row, where you are pulling your hands to your body. If you have weakness in the back of your shoulder, it is a good idea to hold the top of the position for five to ten seconds in order to stimulate your posterior deltoids, rhomboids, external rotators, traps and make them stronger.

RING ROW ECCENTRICS – LEVEL 1



Scapular Positioning: Begin in the top portion of the row position, with your scapulas retracted and depressed. As you slowly lower to the bottom of the row position, allow your scapulas to protract fully.

Technique: Begin in the top portion of the row position and slowly lower to the bottom of the position.

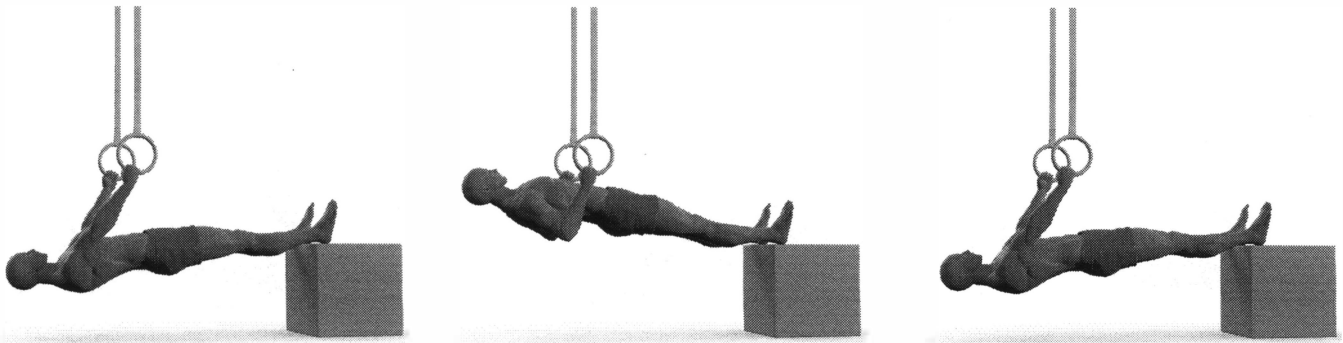
This is the beginning of the rowing progressions. Most beginners will be able to start with ring row eccentrics. If you are having trouble, here are some ways to make the movement easier:

- Instead of positioning your body parallel with the ground, stand more upright and have your feet on the ground. Raise the rings or bar and remove the block from your feet if needed.
- Perform ring row eccentrics in a position with a straddle or bent legs, or from the hips. This will take weight off your arms, which will make the movement easier.
- Put a band through the rings or bar and underneath your back.
- Have another person assist you through the movement.

Some people will have issues maintaining a good range of motion at the top of the movement, or starting the movement from the bottom at level two. Specific scapular retraction work can be worked in these positions with straight arms by focusing on pulling the shoulder blades together. You could also add specific band or other scapular retraction or biceps isolation work at the end of your routine.

Rows tend to respond well to four or five sets. If you are not progressing well, add additional sets to your routine.

RING ROWS – LEVEL 2



Scapular Positioning: Begin at the bottom position, with your shoulders relaxed in a protracted position. Initiate the movement by retracting and depressing your scapulas and end the movement with fully retracted scapulas.

Technique: *Ring rows* are performed by hanging from the rings and elevating your feet to shoulder height while your body is held straight or slightly hollow. Keep your elbows either next to your sides and tight or within a thirty-degree angle (or less) of your armpit. During the movement, pull the rings to your body. Aim to get the rings to chest-level at the top position of the movement.

Your scapulas can retract and depress either at the start of this movement or across the total movement. Beginners are advised to retract and depress them at the start of the movement to have them act as a stable base throughout the movement and help you perform it better. However, as you get more comfortable performing ring rows you can begin to do it unconsciously, which will lead to movement of the scapulas across the total movement.

If you are having trouble with scapular strength in this movement, try holding the top position of the movement for a few seconds between repetitions. Perform this hold with your scapulas maximally contracted and depressed. This will work your scapular retractors, which should improve your strength overall.

The most common fault during this skill is to let your body sag from the straight-body position into a hollow or saggy C-shaped position. Focus on squeezing your glutes and core to keep your body straight and perform the movement with your arms alone.